



The President of the Republic

**ADDRESS BY HIS EXCELLENCY THE PRESIDENT OF THE PORTUGUESE
REPUBLIC**

80TH SESSION OF THE UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY

New York, UN, September 23, 2025

check against delivery

Madam President of the General Assembly,

Mr. Secretary-General,

Your Excellencies,

This is a symbolic moment for the United Nations - the celebration of its 80th anniversary - and for Portugal, which celebrates its 70th year of membership. A time for reflection, but also for commitment and renewed multilateral ambition.

Portugal is today what it always aspired to be. A country open to the world, to listening and dialoguing, committed to building bridges, deeply multilateralist and guided by the United Nations Charter. A world with more international cooperation and respect for international law is safer, more predictable, more stable and peaceful, more prosperous, more plural, more representative and better able to respond collectively to global challenges.

70 years ago, we found in this community a space to uphold our true values and contribute to global solutions, even in today's increasingly fragmented, polarized and unpredictable world. And it is in this same community that we will continue to defend the basic principles of healthy coexistence between nations.



The President of the Republic

It is also with this cohesion and sense of responsibility, with this awareness of the need to contribute, act and decide guided by values and principles, that we are candidates for the Security Council for 2027-2028, a decision formalized in 2013.

Your Excellencies,

I would like to commend the outgoing President, Mr. Philémon Yang, for his leadership in implementing the Pact for the Future. And I would like to congratulate the President of the 80th Session of the General Assembly, Annalena Baerbock, and wish her the greatest success.

I express my appreciation for the tireless work of Secretary-General António Guterres. His humanism, devotion to international law and the reforms he has championed since 2017, now including UN80 and the Pact for the Future, are testaments to his work and will be his legacy. It's a source of pride to have a Portuguese citizen as UNSG and even more so to have someone who embodies the Portuguese ethos in international relations. You will always have Portugal's unwavering support.

Your Excellencies,

We live in a time of multiple and persistent crises, marked by division, polarization and violations of international law. It's a time of division between the exercise of power and responsibility, between technology and ethics, between the urgency of crises and the capacity for response and action. Inevitably affected, the UN is facing an existential juncture as it enters its eighth decade. Without transformation, reinforcement and renewal, the UN will be marginalized, and we will be at the mercy of the rule of force. No G1, G2, G3, G1+2 or G2+1 will provide a solution. We support UN80 and the Pact for the Future, as well as reforms that strengthen the Organization without marginalizing the pillars of development and human rights.

International law cannot be ignored. *We believe in the rule of law as the foundation of international peace and justice. A world governed by rules is a safer and more predictable and equitable world. The Charter of the United Nations must remain our common compass.*



The President of the Republic

The United Nations will have to adapt to our times, but we must not forget the lesson of the League of Nations. History has already shown us what happens when principles are abandoned in the name of pure *realpolitik*.

Your Excellencies,

We believe that, in the process of reforming and transforming the UN, it is crucial to act in three main areas. **Prevention, partnership and protection.**

Prevention: to act before conflict and not only afterwards. Through mediation, preventive diplomacy, the good offices of the Secretary General, and the important role of the Peacebuilding Commission (PBC).

Conflict prevention saves lives, averts destruction and institutional collapse. Peacebuilding tackles the root causes of violence and promotes resilient and peaceful societies.

Prevention is also about development. Together with an African partner - Burundi - Portugal co-chaired the preparation of the 4th Conference on Financing for Development. We did it with ideas, with dialogue, with determination and with results. Because without sustainable development there will be no lasting peace. The implementation of the 2030 Agenda and promoting a balanced reform of the international financial architecture should be a priority for the next five years.

At the same time we are ensuring that digital, space and AI technologies are a force for peace, not tools of domination. Bridging the digital and technological divides is central to building resilient societies.

Aware of the risks posed by climate change to international peace and security, we are also proud to be one of the strongest voices in defence of the oceans initiatives. After UNOC2 in Lisbon and with UNOC3 in Nice, we renewed our commitment to protecting the oceans, being one of the first European states to ratify the BBNJ Agreement, having already protected 27% of our maritime area, just 3% short of the 30% target for 2030. Rising sea levels and plastic pollution are grave threats for several member states and priorities for Portugal.

Your Excellencies,



The President of the Republic

For **Partnership**, we believe that the United Nations will only be able to respond effectively to the challenges of our time if it deepens strategic partnerships, particularly with regional organizations, which are essential for promoting sustainable and inclusive solutions.

On a concrete level, Portugal contributes to building partnerships and consensus. Listening, engaging in dialogue and being present on all continents with equal humility and ambition. As evidenced by The Community of Portuguese-Speaking Countries: nine countries, four continents, one language and shared values on a platform with its own voice at the UN.

We are also committed to dialogue between civilizations, as we demonstrated by hosting the 10th Global Forum of the Alliance of Civilizations in Lisbon, and to combating racism, having hosted the 1st UN Conference on Racism, following the commitments we have also promoted for the global implementation of the Durban Declaration.

We are part of the Ibero-American community. Portugal feels like a brother to Latin America, sharing common priorities such as inclusive multilateralism, sustainable development and social cohesion.

Our partnership with the Global South is built on respect and solidarity. We launched the EU-African Union summits. We have active cooperation with the LDCs (Least Developed Countries), SIDS (Small Island Developing States) and LLDCs (Landlocked Developing Countries).

Partnerships also focusing on women, youth, agents of change, access to education, leadership, political participation and the protection of rights. The world needs more women leaders and young people in decision-making processes.

Madam President,

The third pillar on which we must focus our action to transform the system is **Protection** - the protection of people and rights.

There have been over 65 years of peacekeeping. More than 20,000 soldiers and security forces took part in more than 25 missions on 4



The President of the Republic

continents. This engagement is particularly significant in Africa, where a large part of the future stability is at stake.

A commitment to peacekeeping at a time when such support is decisive. Four peacekeeping operations, including a rapid reaction force, we pay on time, we are on the honour roll and we defend predictable and stable funding, including for missions authorized by the Security Council and led by the African Union.

The protection of civilians is central. This year marks the 25th anniversary of the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict. Children continue to be victims in almost every scenario. We have a legal, political and moral duty to protect them.

We advocate strengthening international humanitarian law, which must be respected by all, without exceptions or conditions. The Geneva Conventions are not suggestions, they are obligations. As president of the 6th Commission at the 79th General Assembly, Portugal contributed to laying the foundations for a Convention on Crimes against Humanity - an essential step, negotiated by consensus, so that the law is not held hostage by politics.

We maintain a deep commitment to human rights. Civil, political, including freedom of expression, economic, social and cultural rights - all of them - are universal, interdependent and indivisible.

Your Excellencies,

We cannot remain indifferent to today's most pressing conflicts and crises, which we must address in the light of the United Nations Charter and international law, including humanitarian law. We defend the same principles - sovereignty, territorial integrity, self-determination - in all geographies, from Europe to Africa and the Middle East.

In the Middle East – a fundamental issue at this General Assembly – the challenge is to create political, economic and social conditions that will strengthen the two State solution. Rebuilding economies and societies by offering an opportunity for peace in the daily lives of Israelis and Palestinians – to live rather than perish.



The President of the Republic

In Ukraine sovereignty, independence and territorial integrity must be upheld. A total, immediate and unconditional ceasefire in Ukraine is the first step towards a just, comprehensive and sustainable peace. To save lives and to stabilize both Europe and the world.

In Sudan, to put an end to the biggest humanitarian catastrophe in Africa.

In Haiti, where the suffering of the population is no longer tenable, given the fear of the barbaric atrocities of criminal gangs and the recruitment of child soldiers. A decisive UN assistance to the Multinational Security Support Mission, before it is too late.

Your Excellencies,

Ladies and gentlemen,

At a time when we are witnessing the largest number of armed conflicts since the creation of the United Nations, Portugal is ready to take on greater responsibilities and represent a global voice in the Security Council, bringing the experience of almost nine centuries of history as a country, the lessons learned in recent decades and the proximity to all the states represented here. Our vision for the Security Council is therefore based on the three pillars I mentioned as essential for the UN - **Prevention, Partnership and Protection**.

And with the reform of the Security Council, to make it more representative and effective. A Council that reflects the geopolitical reality of the 21st century - and doesn't remain stuck in 1945. A Council with a permanent African presence, with SIDS represented and with the recognition of major emerging powers such as Brazil and India. A Council that is more transparent, plural and consistent with the letter and spirit of the Charter.

A Security Council which, in 2024, met frequently, adopted few resolutions and registered the highest number of vetoes since 1989. It is unacceptable that the use of the veto continues to paralyze essential decisions in the face of human suffering. Article 27, paragraph 3 of the Charter is clear: a party to a conflict shall not be the judge of its own case. Portugal supports the ACT



The President of the Republic

group's Code of Conduct, measures to restrict the use of veto and all initiatives that strengthen transparency and accountability within the Council.

Your Excellencies,

Portugal is presenting itself to the Security Council without hidden agendas, but rather with an agenda aligned with the values and objectives of the UN. With humility, but with confidence, we propose to contribute to a Council that is more effective, representative and close to those who expect protection from it.

Portugal is a predictable country, a bridge-builder, a reliable partner and, above all, an uncompromising defender of the UN Charter. It is in this spirit that we want to serve, that we reaffirm our commitment to the United Nations today and that we hope will earn your trust.

Thank you.